

Case Study: Cyberbullying – When Screens Become Weapons

Introduction

Cyberbullying represents one of the most insidious forms of modern harassment, leveraging digital platforms to inflict repeated, intentional harm. Unlike traditional bullying, which is often confined to physical spaces and limited hours, cyberbullying invades every corner of a victim's life through smartphones, social media, and messaging apps. It involves actions such as posting humiliating content, spreading rumors, sending abusive messages, or creating fake profiles to impersonate or target individuals. The permanence and viral nature of online content amplify the damage, often leaving victims feeling isolated, powerless, and under constant surveillance. In India, where smartphone penetration among youth exceeds 70% and social media usage is among the highest globally, cyberbullying has emerged as a critical public health and educational concern, particularly in college environments.

How Cyberbullying Typically Unfolds

It frequently originates from personal grievances—a breakup, academic rivalry, jealousy, or even a minor disagreement. The perpetrator may use their own account or create anonymous profiles on Instagram, WhatsApp, Telegram, or X (formerly Twitter). Common tactics include morphing photos (using AI tools to create explicit or degrading images), leaking private chats, or flooding comment sections with derogatory remarks. The content is then shared in group chats, college forums, or stories, rapidly escalating into collective participation through likes, shares, and comments. This “pile-on” effect transforms individual malice into communal shaming. Victims face relentless notifications, doxxing (revealing personal details), and threats, making escape nearly impossible without disconnecting entirely from digital life. The anonymity of the internet lowers inhibitions, allowing bullies to act without immediate fear of consequences.

Who is Most Vulnerable?

In the Indian context, college students aged 18–24 form the primary demographic at risk, especially young women and those from minority communities (religious, caste, or regional). Public or semi-public social media profiles—common among active users—make them easy targets. A 2024 meta-analysis estimated the pooled prevalence of cyberbullying among Indian adolescents at around 19%, while surveys of higher education students (aged 17–24) report victimization rates as high as 53.6%. Research from 2024–2025 indicates that girls face disproportionate sexualized harassment, including morphed explicit images and slut-shaming. India consistently ranks among the top countries globally for parental reports of child cyberbullying (up to 38% in some surveys), underscoring the scale of the issue.

The Case of Priya Sharma: A Real-Life Like Scenario

Priya Sharma, a 20-year-old second-year B.Tech student at a reputed engineering college in Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh, embodied the typical victim profile. Outgoing and academically strong, she maintained an active but private Instagram account where she shared college life,

friends, and occasional selfies. In October 2025, after a messy breakup with her boyfriend of eight months, the relationship soured dramatically. Feeling rejected, he created a fake Instagram handle mimicking a common student name. Using basic photo-editing apps (and potentially AI tools increasingly accessible to youth), he produced a morphed explicit image superimposing Priya's face onto an obscene body. He added vulgar captions, her full name, college roll number, and batch details, tagging it with hashtags popular among engineering students.

Within hours, he circulated the link in their batch WhatsApp group (over 150 members) and a few class-specific Telegram channels. By the next day, the post had spread virally across multiple college groups, Instagram stories, and even Snapchat. Students—some known to Priya, others complete strangers—began liking, commenting with derogatory slurs (“slut,” “characterless”), and forwarding screenshots. Priya's phone flooded with hundreds of abusive direct messages, rape threats, and unsolicited explicit content. Classmates who once greeted her warmly now avoided eye contact or whispered behind her back.

The psychological toll was immediate and devastating. Priya skipped lectures for two weeks, fearing judgment in the classroom. She deleted all social media accounts, but the damage lingered—screenshots circulated offline via Bluetooth and WhatsApp. Nightmares, panic attacks, and constant anxiety replaced her cheerful demeanor. Her parents, initially unaware, noticed her withdrawal only when her attendance dropped below 50% and mid-semester grades plummeted from distinction level to failing in two subjects. A college counselor later diagnosed severe anxiety and depression; Priya required three months of therapy, including cognitive behavioral sessions and medication, before partially resuming studies. The perpetrator faced no immediate repercussions because tracing the fake account proved difficult without prompt police intervention. This case mirrors rising trends in Madhya Pradesh and other states, where engineering colleges have seen similar incidents involving deepfake-style harassment.

Consequences: Beyond the Screen

The repercussions of cyberbullying extend far beyond emotional distress. Victims like Priya often experience eroded self-esteem, social withdrawal, and long-term mental health issues such as depression, anxiety disorders, sleep disturbances, and even suicidal ideation. Studies link cyber-victimization to a 30% noticeable decline in academic performance among Indian students, with many dropping out or losing scholarships. In extreme cases, it has led to suicides among young adults. Physically, victims report headaches, appetite loss, and psychosomatic symptoms. Academically and socially, the stigma can damage future job prospects, as employers increasingly screen online footprints. For minority or female students, it reinforces systemic vulnerabilities, perpetuating cycles of inequality.

Legal Framework in India

While India lacks a dedicated anti-cyberbullying law, existing provisions offer recourse. The Information Technology Act, 2000 (as amended) is the primary weapon:

- **Section 67:** Punishes publication or transmission of obscene material in electronic form (up to 3 years imprisonment and fine).
- **Section 67A:** Addresses sexually explicit content (harsher penalties).
- **Sections 66C and 66D:** Cover identity theft and cheating by impersonation (up to 3 years and ₹1 lakh fine).

The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) supplements this with provisions for defamation, criminal intimidation, and sexual harassment. Social media intermediaries must remove harmful content within hours of notification under IT Rules. Victims can file complaints at cyber cells or use the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal. However, challenges persist: slow investigations, difficulty in tracing anonymous accounts, low awareness, and under-reporting (many victims fear further exposure). Landmark judicial interpretations have strengthened enforcement, but gaps remain in addressing AI-generated deepfakes.

Broader Implications and Statistics

Cyberbullying is not isolated. Uttar Pradesh alone recorded 66,854 cases in 2024—one every eight minutes—with youth (16–25) comprising over two-thirds. National surveys show 32–57% of young adults affected, with mental health costs including heightened suicidal thoughts (victims 2.5 times more likely). Colleges, as microcosms of society, amplify risks through dense digital networks.

Prevention and Response Strategies

Effective prevention demands a multi-layered approach:

1. **Education and Awareness:** Mandatory digital literacy workshops in colleges on consent, privacy settings, and ethical online behavior.
2. **Institutional Policies:** Colleges should establish anti-cyberbullying cells, anonymous reporting apps, and swift disciplinary action (suspension/expulsion for perpetrators).
3. **Parental and Peer Support:** Open family dialogues and bystander intervention training.
4. **Technological Safeguards:** Platforms must enhance AI moderation for morphed content; users should enable two-factor authentication and report promptly.
5. **Government and Legal:** Faster cyber cell responses, awareness campaigns via UGC/AICTE, and potential new legislation for deepfakes. Guidelines from bodies like NCPCR emphasize school/college-level protocols for early detection.

Key Reflection and Conclusion

Priya's ordeal illustrates a harsh truth: one impulsive post or share can shatter lives. In an era where screens are extensions of self, empathy must guide every click. Colleges, families, and society must shift from reactive punishment to proactive empowerment—teaching respect, resilience, and responsibility. Victims like Priya recover, but scars remain. By fostering digital citizenship, India can transform online spaces from weapons into safe arenas for connection and growth.

Recommendations for Stakeholders

- **Students:** Think before posting; block/report immediately; seek counseling.
- **Colleges:** Integrate cyber ethics into curriculum; conduct regular audits of campus groups.
- **Parents:** Monitor without invading privacy; model healthy digital habits.
- **Government:** Accelerate portal integration and AI regulation.